

POL101-20

Weber, Krasner, and Tilly: Modern State, Sovereignty, and State-Making

Where We Are in the Course

1. We began by defining politics through Heywood and narrowing its boundary through Sartori.
2. Classical thinkers helped us ask why authority becomes necessary, accepted, or legitimate.
3. Kautilya and Machiavelli shifted us toward statecraft: how rule is organized and maintained.
4. Now we move to the modern state, sovereignty, state-making, political economy, and nationhood.

Core Definitions Revisited

1. **Definition:** What is politics, and where does politics begin?
2. Authority: Why do humans need rule, order, consent, rights, and legitimacy?
3. State: How does authority become organized through institutions and administration?
4. Sovereignty: Who has final authority, recognition, autonomy, and control?
5. Political economy and nation: Who gets what, and who belongs to the political community?

Today's Learning Goals

1. Clarify the difference between polis, state, modern state, nation, and nation-state.
2. Use Weber to define the modern state as a territorial claim to legitimate force.
3. Use Krasner to show that sovereignty has multiple meanings and is often compromised.
4. Use Tilly to explain how war, extraction, protection, and state-making build capacity.

Polis, State, Modern State

1. Polis: an ancient Greek political community tied to citizenship, public life, and the good life.
2. State: an organized structure that rules a territory and population through authority and institutions (Population, Territory, Government, Authority)
3. Modern state: a more centralized and bureaucratic form of rule that claims legitimate force within territory.
4. Key distinction: polis asks how people live well together; modern state asks who rules, administers, and enforces.

State, Country, Nation, Nation-State

1. State: legal-political authority, institutions, territory, population, and rule.
2. Country: everyday word for a territorial place or political unit; less precise than state.
3. Nation: peoplehood; a community that imagines itself as belonging together.
4. Nation-state: when state authority and national identity mostly overlap, though never perfectly.

Reflection 1

When does a place become more than territory and become a political community?

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When does a place become more than territory and become a political community?

Think: people, authority, institutions, identity, and recognition.

Weber

The modern state as legitimate force, territory, and administration

Weber Starts by Narrowing Politics

1. Politics can mean many leadership activities in ordinary language.
2. Weber narrows the focus to leadership or influence over a political organization: the state.
3. This connects to Sartori: politics becomes too vague if it means every kind of influence.
4. The key question becomes: what is specific to the modern state?

Weber's Definition of the Modern State

1. The modern state is a human community that successfully claims the monopoly of legitimate physical violence within a particular territory.
2. It is not defined only by what it does, because states have performed many different tasks.
3. It is defined sociologically by its specific means: legitimate physical force.
4. Territory is essential because the claim operates within a bounded space.

Unpacking Weber's Definition

1. Human community: the state is a relationship of rule over people.
2. Territory: state authority is tied to a defined space.
3. Monopoly: other actors may use force only when the state permits it.
4. Legitimate: force is treated as rightful public authority, not private violence.

Important Clarification

1. Weber does not say the state uses force all the time.
2. He does not say force is the state's only tool.
3. He says force is the state's distinctive means in the modern period.
4. A state claims the right to authorize legitimate force; reality may be messy or incomplete.

Weber: Politics as Power

1. Politics means striving for a share of power or influence over the distribution of power.
2. This can happen between states or among groups inside a state.
3. Power may serve ideals, interests, security, prestige, or office.
4. This connects Weber to Heywood's definition of politics as power.

Weber: Why People Obey

1. The state is a relationship in which people rule over other people.
2. Rule survives when those who are ruled accept or acquiesce in authority.
3. Weber asks why people treat rule as legitimate.
4. This brings Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau back into the modern state discussion.

Three Grounds of Legitimate Rule

1. Traditional authority: people obey because custom and the past make rule seem rightful.
2. Charismatic authority: people obey because they believe in the extraordinary person or leader.
3. Legal-rational authority: people obey offices, rules, law, procedure, and competence.
4. Weber calls these pure types; real political life often mixes them.

Administration and the Modern State

1. Every ruling apparatus needs obedience and material resources.
2. The modern state depends on officials, staff, records, money, buildings, supplies, and equipment.
3. Officials are separated from personal ownership of administrative resources.
4. This is the shift from personal rule toward institutional rule.

Reflection Question 2

Is the modern state stronger because it has force, law, administration, or legitimacy?

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Best answer: it needs all four, but Weber helps us see their different roles.

Krasner

Sovereignty as a model, a typology, and a problem

Why Krasner Comes After Weber

1. Weber defines the modern state through legitimate force within territory.
2. Krasner asks what sovereignty means in the international system.
3. The Westphalian model imagines states as territorial, autonomous, recognized, and in control.
4. Krasner's main warning: this model is elegant, but it has never perfectly described reality.

The Sovereign State Model

1. Territory: political authority is tied to a defined geographic space.
2. Autonomy: no external actor should exercise authority inside the state.
3. Mutual recognition: states recognize one another as legally competent actors.
4. Control: states are expected to regulate movement across and within their borders.

Krasner's Main Claim

1. The sovereign state model is a powerful script, not a perfect description.
2. There was no pure golden age of sovereignty.
3. States often defend sovereignty as a norm while violating it in practice.
4. This gap between principle and action is what Krasner calls organized hypocrisy.

Four Meanings of Sovereignty

1. Interdependence sovereignty: ability to control cross-border flows of people, goods, capital, ideas, and disease.
2. Domestic sovereignty: authority structures inside the state and their practical control over behavior.
3. Vattelian sovereignty: exclusion of external authority from domestic affairs.
4. International legal sovereignty: mutual recognition among juridically independent territorial entities.

Sovereignty Is a Basket

1. A state may have international recognition but weak domestic control.
2. A state may have legal authority but limited border control.
3. A state may voluntarily accept outside rules and still keep recognition.
4. Therefore, sovereignty is not one single thing; its parts do not always move together.

How Sovereignty is Compromised

1. Conventions: voluntary commitments that expose domestic conduct to external standards.
2. Contracting: states accept limits because others also honor a bargain.
3. Coercion: stronger actors use threats or pressure against weaker actors.
4. Imposition: the weaker actor has little meaningful choice but to comply.

Reflection Question 3

Can a state be recognized internationally but still struggle to control territory or borders?

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Krasner's answer: yes. That is why sovereignty must be unpacked.

Tilly

State-making as coercion, protection, extraction, and organization

Why Tilly Comes After Krasner

1. Weber defines the modern state.
2. Krasner unpacks sovereignty and shows why the model is often compromised.
3. Tilly asks how national states were historically built.
4. His answer is difficult but important: coercion, war, extraction, and resistance shaped state formation.

Tilly's Starting Point

1. Tilly studies national states as centralized and differentiated organizations.
2. Officials claim control over the chief concentrated means of violence.
3. His famous claim: war makes states.
4. He warns that war making, policing, banditry, and organized force can sit on the same continuum.

Double-Edged Protection

1. Protection can mean safety from danger.
2. Protection can also resemble a racket if the protector creates or inflates the threat.
3. Tilly uses this uncomfortable analogy to make students question how authority becomes normal.
4. This is an analytical argument, not a claim that all states are only criminal organizations.

Tilly's Four Activities

1. War making: eliminating or neutralizing external rivals.
2. State making: eliminating or neutralizing internal rivals.
3. Protection: eliminating or neutralizing enemies of clients or allies.
4. Extraction: acquiring the resources needed to do the first three.

War, Extraction, Capital

1. Power holders fought wars to defeat competitors and secure territory.
2. War required money, people, arms, food, transport, and supplies.
3. This pushed rulers to extract resources through taxation, debt, and administration.
4. War making, extraction, and capital accumulation interacted to shape European state-making.

State-Making Also Produces Constraints

1. Tilly does not only describe coercion from above.
2. Popular resistance to coercive extraction forced rulers to concede protection and constraints.
3. The state became stronger, but subjects also gained claims, bargaining power, and representation in some cases.
4. This prepares us for political economy: state power and resources develop together.

Consider not Overgeneralizing Tilly

1. Tilly is mainly explaining European state formation.
2. He warns against simple comparisons between Europe's past and other regions today.
3. His argument is not that all modern states formed in exactly the same way.
4. Use Tilly as a model of how coercion, extraction, and organization can build state capacity.

Putting the Readings Together

Weber defines; Krasner unpacks; Tilly explains formation

How Weber, Krasner, and Tilly Speak to Each Other

1. Weber: What is distinctive about the modern state? Legitimate force within territory.
2. Krasner: What does sovereignty mean? It has multiple dimensions and frequent compromises.
3. Tilly: How were strong states built? Through war, extraction, protection, coercion, and organization.
4. Together: the state is authority, territory, legitimacy, capacity, and history.

Claim, Capacity, Legitimacy

1. Sovereignty is the claim to final authority over territory and population.
2. Capacity is the practical ability to implement rules through resources and administration.
3. Legitimacy is why people accept authority as rightful.
4. A strong modern state usually needs all three: claim, capacity, and legitimacy.

Let's think:

1. Weber: the traffic officer acts through the state's legitimate authority, not private force.
2. Krasner: authority depends on territory, control, recognition, and boundaries.
3. Tilly: traffic systems require extraction, administration, enforcement, and public compliance.
4. The ordinary road becomes a window into state power.

Bridge to Political Economy

1. If the state needs administration, force, and capacity, it also needs resources.
2. Resources raise political economy questions: taxation, property, labor, capital, welfare, and distribution.
3. Tilly already points forward: war making and extraction create financial and administrative structures.
4. Next step: how state power and economic life shape each other.

Bridge to Nation and Nationalism

1. The state asks: who rules and enforces?
2. The nation asks: who are the people?
3. A nation-state claims that political authority and national identity mostly overlap.
4. Later readings on Gellner and Anderson will ask how national belonging is produced and imagined.

Midterm Preparation

1. Do not memorize thinkers as isolated names.
2. Build the course arc: definition, authority, state, sovereignty, political economy, nation.
3. Use readings comparatively: one defines, one questions, one explains how the concept works.
4. A strong essay defines the concept, locates the site, compares thinkers, and uses evidence.

Reflection

What changes when we stop seeing the state as only a service provider and start seeing it as authority, capacity, and legitimacy?

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1. **Weber** shows that the modern state is not defined mainly by the services it provides, but by its claim to legitimate authority over force within a territory.
2. **Krasner** shows that sovereignty is not one complete package; states may have recognition, autonomy, border control, and domestic authority in uneven ways, so sovereignty is often compromised in practice.
3. **Tilly** shows that modern states were built through war-making, extraction, protection, and the attempt to monopolize organized violence; state capacity grew from these historical struggles.

What did we do today?

1. Weber gives the modern state its defining feature: legitimate force within territory.
2. Krasner shows that sovereignty is plural, contested, and often compromised.
3. Tilly shows that states are historically built through coercion, extraction, protection, and resistance.
4. The next unit asks how this state organizes economic life and national belonging.